argument with one of his instructors. “I was getting very heated and accusing him, more or less, of dishonesty. He was getting heated too and said ‘You’re going too far.’ But I was very engaged and angry that we couldn’t get all that clear.”

Frustrated, Bell started reading works by the founders of quantum physics, in hopes of clearing up his confusion. What he found there was not particularly helpful. Bohr was unclear about where the division between the quantum and the classical world lay. “[Bohr] seems to have been extraordinarily insensitive to the fact that we have this beautiful mathematics, and we don’t know which part of the world it should be applied to,” said Bell. “Bohr seemed to think he had solved this question. I could not find the solution in his writings. But there was no doubt that he was convinced that he had solved the problem and, in so doing, had not only contributed to atomic physics, but to epistemology, to philosophy, to humanity in general.” And Heisenberg’s writing was “perfectly obscure” to Bell. The measurement problem was clearly a serious issue, but the Copenhagen interpretation treated it like it was trivial. Bell wanted rigor and honesty; instead, his deep questions were waved away with insubstantial answers.

Then Bell encountered von Neumann’s proof—really Max Born’s account of von Neumann’s proof, since Bell couldn’t read German. “I was very impressed that somebody—von Neumann—had actually *proved* that you couldn’t interpret quantum mechanics” in some other way, Bell said. So he moved on. “For me, it was a big risk that I would get hung up on these questions once I learned about them.… I rather deliberately walked away from them,” Bell recalled. “I had the feeling then that getting involved in these questions so early might be a hole I wouldn’t get out of.”

After graduating from Queens, Bell found a job with the Atomic Energy Research Establishment in Harwell, England, working on nuclear reactors with Klaus Fuchs, a veteran of the Manhattan Project. But several months after Bell arrived, Fuchs confessed to passing atomic secrets to the Soviets, and Bell was reassigned to the accelerator physics division. While there, he met Mary Ross, a fellow physicist and his future wife. And it was while John and Mary were working at Harwell that John encountered Bohm’s pilot-wave papers in 1952, shortly after they were first published.